

IH04

Gupta, Post-Gupta and South Indian Dynasties

About 2-3 questions a paper from this chapter. The proven favourites are the Guptas

(Samudragupta's Prayag Prashasti, Prabhavati Gupta and the Vakatakas), the Rashtrakuta Kailasa temple at Ellora, and the Chola temples. Match-the-following and NOT-correctly-matched formats dominate.

Roughly a thousand years of Indian history - 320 CE to 1300 CE - packed into one chapter. Do not try to learn it as a story. RPSC asks it as a matching grid: ruler to inscription, ruler to monument, king to court poet, dynasty to capital. Learn the grid.

Guptas, Post-Gupta and the South

Guptas (c. 319-550 CE)

- Sri Gupta - founder
- Samudragupta - Prayag Prashasti
- Chandragupta II - Sakari, Vakataka tie
- Kumaragupta I - Nalanda
- Skandagupta - Hunas repelled

Vardhanas /

Pushyabhutis

- Harsha 606-647 CE
- Thanesar to Kannauj
- Banabhatta - Harshacharita
- Hiuen Tsang - Si-yu-ki
- Stopped at the Narmada

Eastern & Deccan north

- Palas - Gopala, Dharmapala
- Senas - Lakshmanasena, Jayadeva
- Rashtrakutas - Dantidurga, Krishna I
- Tripartite struggle for Kannauj

Deccan & Pallavas

- Chalukyas of Badami - Pulakeshin II
- Aihole inscription - Ravikirti
- Chalukyas of Kalyani - Vikramaditya VI
- Pallavas - Mahendravarman, Narasimhavarman
- Mamallapuram, Kanchi

The far south

- Cholas - Rajaraja I, Rajendra I
- Uttaramerur - kudavolai
- Hoysalas - Belur, Halebidu
- Kakatiyas - Warangal, Rudramadevi
- Sangam - Chola tiger, Pandya fish, Chera bow

The frame - fix the grid before the story

This chapter covers two Indias at once. In the north: Guptas, then Harsha, then the Palas, Senas and Rashtrakutas fighting over Kannauj. In the south: Chalukyas, Pallavas, Cholas, and after them the Hoysalas and Kakatiyas. RPSC never asks you to narrate a war. It asks one of four things - who ruled from where, who wrote what, who built what, and which inscription says what. So build the grid first.

Dynasty to capital to the one ruler you must know

Dynasty	Capital	Ruler to remember
Guptas	Pataliputra	Samudragupta
Vardhanas (Pushyabhutis)	Thanesar, later Kannauj	Harshavardhana
Palas	Bengal-Bihar (Gaur, Munger)	Dharmapala, Devapala
Senas	Lakshmanavati (Gaur)	Lakshmanasena
Rashtrakutas	Manyakheta (Malkhed)	Krishna I, Amoghavarsha I
Chalukyas of Badami	Vatapi (Badami)	Pulakeshin II
Chalukyas of Kalyani	Kalyani	Vikramaditya VI
Pallavas	Kanchi (Kanchipuram)	Narasimhavarman I
Cholas	Thanjavur, then Gangaikonda Cholapuram	Rajaraja I, Rajendra I
Hoysalas	Dwarasamudra (Halebidu)	Vishnuvardhana
Kakatiyas	Warangal (Orugallu)	Rudramadevi, Prataparudra II
Pandyas (Sangam)	Madurai, port Korkai	Emblem - fish
Cheras (Sangam)	Vanji, port Muziris	Emblem - bow and arrow

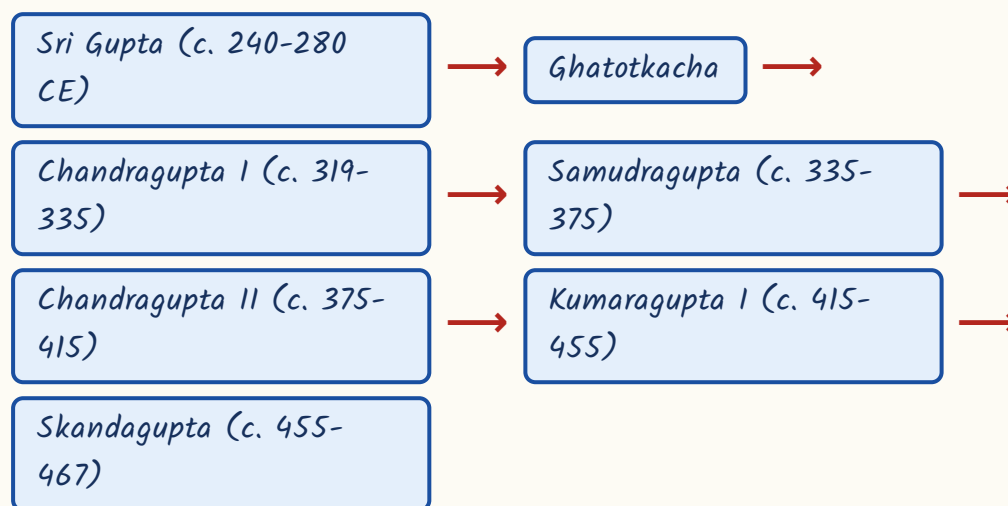
YAAD RAKHO

Store every dynasty in five slots: capital, one ruler, one monument, one book, one inscription. When RPSC gives you a match-the-following, you are only reading off those slots.

The Guptas take shape - Sri Gupta to Chandragupta I

The Guptas begin small. Sri Gupta is named in Gupta inscriptions as the founder, and he carried only the modest title Maharaja - a local chief, not an emperor. His son Ghatotkacha kept the same title. The jump comes with Chandragupta I, who takes the imperial title Maharajadhiraja and marries into the powerful Licchavi clan. That marriage is the political turning point, and it is why RPSC keeps asking about it.

The Gupta line - learn this order, it is asked as an ordering question



- Sri Gupta - founder, title only Maharaja.
- Chandragupta I - first Gupta to take Maharajadhiraja.
- Married the Licchavi princess Kumaradevi.
- Issued the King-Queen type gold coins showing both.
- Gupta era begins 319-320 CE - the standard reckoning date.

TRAP

Three men, one name. Chandragupta Maurya (4th century BCE, Chanakya), Chandragupta I (Licchavi marriage, Gupta era), Chandragupta II Vikramaditya (Sakari, Vakataka alliance). RPSC has set options mixing all three.

Samudragupta and the Prayag Prashasti

Samudragupta is the conqueror of the line. Everything we know about his campaigns comes from one document - the Allahabad or Prayag Prashasti, composed by his court poet Harisena in champu style, that is a mix of prose and verse in Sanskrit. Note the irony that gets asked: it is engraved on an Ashokan pillar. So one pillar carries a message of peace from Ashoka and a war record from Samudragupta.

- Composed by Harisena, court poet - champu (prose plus verse) Sanskrit.
- Engraved on an Ashokan pillar at Prayag (Allahabad).
- Titles - Kaviraja (king among poets), Ashvamedha-parakrama.
- Called the Napoleon of India by V.A. Smith - a historian's label, not a title of his.
- Lyrist type coins show him playing the veena; also ashvamedha type coins.

The two policies in the Prayag Prashasti - this contrast is the exam point

Aryavarta (the north)	Dakshinapatha (the south)
Kings were uprooted - prasabhodharana	Kings were defeated, then reinstated
Territory annexed outright	Policy of grahana-moksha-anugraha - capture, release, favour
Nine kings named as uprooted	Twelve southern kings named
Direct Gupta rule	Tribute and acknowledgement of overlordship

Chandragupta II Vikramaditya - the peak, and the two Chinese travellers

Chandragupta II is where the Gupta empire is at its widest and its richest. His big military achievement is finishing off the Western Kshatrapas, the Shaka rulers of Malwa and Gujarat - which is why he takes the title Sakari, slayer of the Shakas. That conquest gave the Guptas the western ports, and it also gave them silver: Gupta silver coinage begins only after this, because the Kshatrapas had a silver coin tradition and the Guptas continued it.

- Title Sakari after destroying the Western Kshatrapas of Malwa-Gujarat.
- First Gupta silver coinage; Ujjain became a second centre of power.
- Lion-slayer and horseman type gold coins are his.
- Navaratna, first four - Kalidasa, Amarasingha (Amarakosha), Varahamihira, Dhanvantari.
- Navaratna, next five - Vararuchi, Kshapanaka, Shanku, Ghatakarpara, Vetabhatta.
- The Navaratna list is traditional, not proved by inscription - but learn it, RPSC asks it as a list.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked twice in RAS Pre 2021, on the same alliance. (1) Chandragupta II married his daughter Prabhavati Gupta to the Vakataka ruler - answer: Rudrasena II. (2) After her husband's early death Prabhavati ruled as regent for her minor son - answer: Divakarasena. Her mother was the Naga princess Kuberanaga, and the Poona copper plates call her the mother of Yuvaraja Divakarasena.

- Fa-Hien (Faxian) visited India c. 399-414 CE, in Chandragupta II's reign.

- His account is the Fo-Kuo-Ki, Record of Buddhist Kingdoms.
- He came for Buddhist texts - he is silent on politics and never names the king.
- Hiuen Tsang came later, under Harsha; do not swap the two.

Kumaragupta I, Skandagupta and the inscription grid

Kumaragupta I ruled long and quietly, and his one permanent contribution is Nalanda - he founded the Mahavihara that became the greatest university of early India. His title was Mahendraditya and his coins carry the peacock, the vehicle of Kartikeya. Skandagupta then faces the Hunas. He beats them back, but the effort drains the treasury, and the Gupta decline sets in after him.

- Kumaragupta I (c. 415-455) - title Mahendraditya, founded Nalanda Mahavihara.
- Peacock type coins - linked to Kartikeya worship.
- Mandsaur inscription of his reign records a silk-weavers' guild that migrated and rebuilt a sun temple.
- Skandagupta (c. 455-467) - repelled the Hunas; last of the great Guptas.

Inscription to ruler to what it records - a standing matching question

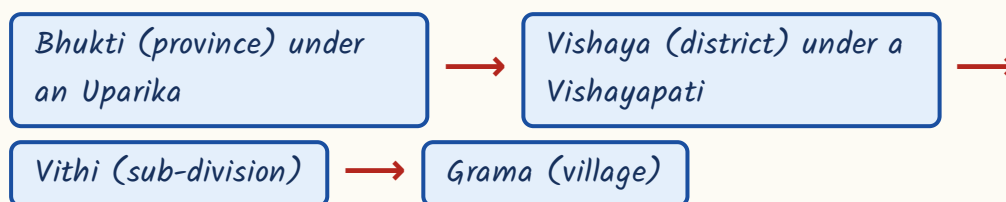
Inscription	Ruler	What it records
Allahabad / Prayag Prashasti	Samudragupta	Conquests; composed by Harisena
Junagadh rock inscription	Skandagupta	Repair of the Sudarshana lake in Saurashtra
Bhitari pillar inscription	Skandagupta	Victories over the Pushyamitras and the Hunas
Mandsaur inscription	Kumaragupta I	Silk-weavers' guild, sun temple
Poona copper plates	Prabhavati Gupta	Her regency for Yuvaraja Divakarasena

Inscription	Ruler	What it records
Mehrauli iron pillar	King Chandra (Chandragupta II)	Praise of Chandra; rust-free iron

Gupta administration, land and coins

Gupta government was looser than Mauryan government. The Mauryas ran a centralised bureaucracy; the Guptas ran a layered structure where provincial governors and local bodies had real room. The other big shift is land grants - kings began granting revenue-free villages to brahmanas and temples, which over centuries created a landed intermediary class. That is the standard explanation of Indian feudalism, and it starts here.

The administrative ladder - top to bottom



- Kumaramatyas - the highest cadre of officers, drawn on for top posts.
- Gold coin was called the dinara; Gupta gold coinage is the finest of ancient India.
- Agrahara - revenue-free grant to a brahmana; devagrahara - grant to a temple.
- Land grants were often made permanent and tax-free, weakening central revenue.
- Gupta-age science belongs here too - Aryabhata and Varahamihira; the detail is in the art and science chapter.

Coin type to ruler - a clean one-mark question

Coin type	Ruler
King-Queen type	Chandragupta I
Lyrist (veena) and ashvamedha type	Samudragupta
Lion-slayer, horseman, couch type	Chandragupta II
Peacock type	Kumaragupta I

Harsha and the Pushyabhutis - the last northern empire before the Turks

Harshavardhana belongs to the Pushyabhuti or Vardhana dynasty of Thanesar. He shifted his capital to Kannauj, and from then on Kannauj becomes the prize of north India - which is exactly why the tripartite struggle later happens over it. Harsha ruled 606 to 647 CE. His expansion southwards stopped hard: the Chalukya king Pulakeshin II beat him on the Narmada, and the Narmada stayed his southern limit.

- Reign 606-647 CE; titles Siladitya and Rajaputra.
- Capital shifted from Thanesar to Kannauj.
- Defeated by Chalukya Pulakeshin II on the Narmada, c. 618-619 CE.
- Madhuban and Banskhera copper plates are his own records.
- Banabhatta, his court poet, wrote the Harshacharita (his biography) and the Kadambari (a prose romance).
- Harsha himself wrote three Sanskrit plays - Nagananda, Ratnavali, Priyadarshika.
- Hiuen Tsang, the Prince of Pilgrims, wrote the Si-yu-ki.
- Kannauj religious assembly, 643 CE; Prayag Mahamoksha Parishad held every five years.

TRAP

Kadambari was written by Banabhatta, not by Harsha. Harsha wrote the three plays. A NOT-correct question has been built on exactly this swap.

After Harsha - Palas, Senas, Rashtrakutas and the fight for

Kannauj

Harsha died without an heir and north India broke up. Three powers then spent nearly a century fighting over Kannauj - the Palas from the east, the Gurjara-Pratiharas from the west, and the Rashtrakutas from the Deccan. This is the tripartite struggle. Nobody won it permanently; all three exhausted themselves, and that weakness is part of why the Turkish invasions later succeeded.

- Palas of Bengal-Bihar - Gopala was elected founder, c. 750 CE; election is the point RPSC likes.
 - Gopala built Odantapuri; Dharmapala founded Vikramshila and Somapura Mahavihara (Paharpur).
 - Devapala is counted the greatest Pala; the Palas were Buddhist patrons.
 - Palas patronised the Nalanda and Vikramshila monasteries and the Pala school of bronzes.
 - Senas replaced the Palas in Bengal - Samantasena, Vijayasena, Ballalasena, Lakshmanasena.
 - Ballalasena wrote Danasagara and Adbhutasagara.
 - Jayadeva, author of the Gita Govinda, adorned Lakshmanasena's court.
 - Lakshmanasena was ruling when Bakhtiyar Khalji took Bengal.
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- Rashtrakutas - founder Dantidurga; capital Manyakheta (Malkhed).
 - Krishna I built the monolithic Kailasa temple, Cave 16 at Ellora.

- Amoghavarsha I wrote Kavirajamarga, the earliest extant literary work in Kannada, and founded Manyakheta.
- Arab traveller accounts rank the Rashtrakuta king among the great kings of the world.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2023 asked: the monolithic Kailasa temple at Ellora (Cave 16) was excavated under which Rashtrakuta ruler? Answer - Krishna I. Remember the pairing Krishna I - Kailasa - Ellora - Rashtrakuta as a single unit; it is the single most asked fact of the post-Gupta north.

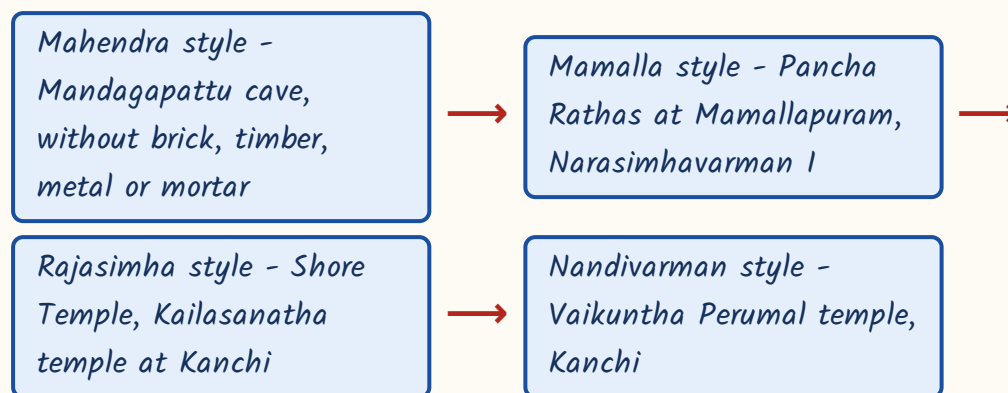
The Deccan and the Pallavas - Badami against Kanchi

From the sixth to the eighth century the Deccan is one long duel: the Chalukyas of Badami against the Pallavas of Kanchi. Pulakeshin II is the Chalukya high point - he stopped Harsha on the Narmada. But then Pallava Narasimhavarman I marched south to north, captured the Chalukya capital Vatapi in 642 CE, and took the title Vatapikonda, conqueror of Vatapi. Pulakeshin II was defeated and killed. Learn the duel as one story and both sides fall into place.

- Pulakeshin II (610-642 CE) of Badami - defeated Harsha, defeated by Narasimhavarman I.
- Aihole inscription, composed by the Jain poet Ravikirti on the Meguti temple, Saka 556 (634-35 CE), records his victories.
- Pattadakal Virupaksha temple - built by queen Lokamahadevi for Vikramaditya II's victory over Kanchi.
- Pattadakal is a UNESCO World Heritage Site, inscribed 1987.
- Narasimhavarman I Mamalla captured Vatapi in 642 CE - title Vatapikonda.
- Mahendravarman I wrote the Sanskrit farce Mattavilasa Prahasana.

- Mamallapuram's monuments are a UNESCO World Heritage Site.
- Chalukyas of Kalyani - the later revival branch.
- Vikramaditya VI - court poet Bilhana wrote Vikramankadevacharita; jurist Vijnaneshwara wrote the Mitakshara.
- The Mitakshara is a commentary on the Yajnavalkya Smriti and became a school of Hindu law.
- Someshvara III wrote the Manasollasa, an encyclopaedic work.

Pallava architecture in four stages - asked as an ordering question



ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2023 asked a NOT-correctly-matched question on monument and builder dynasty. The wrong pair was Dashavatara temple, Deogarh - Pallavas. Deogarh is Gupta. Keep four pairs ready: Deogarh - Guptas, Kailasa Ellora - Rashtrakutas, Shore Temple - Pallavas, Virupaksha Pattadakal - Chalukyas of Badami.

TRAP

Three Chalukya branches, do not merge them - Badami or Vatapi (Pulakeshin II), Kalyani (Vikramaditya VI), and the Eastern Chalukyas of Vengi. Also keep Chalukya separate from Chola: Chalukya is Deccan and Kannada, Chola is Tamil.

The far south - Cholas, their village republics, and the last Deccan kingdoms

The imperial Cholas were revived by Vijayalaya around 850 CE with Thanjavur as capital, and under Rajaraja I and Rajendra I they became the strongest naval and temple-building power India had seen. Rajaraja I built the Brihadeshwara temple at Thanjavur, consecrated in 1010 CE. His son Rajendra I marched to the Ganga, took the title Gangaikondachola, founded a new capital called Gangaikonda Cholapuram, and sent a fleet across the sea against Srivijaya - the Kadaram expedition. No other Indian dynasty of the period did that.

- Vijayalaya revived the line c. 850 CE, capital Thanjavur.
- Rajaraja I - Brihadeshwara or Rajarajeshwara temple, consecrated 1010 CE.
- Rajendra I - Gangaikondachola, new capital Gangaikonda Cholapuram, naval expedition to Srivijaya (Kadaram).
- Rajaraja II built the Airavatesvara temple at Darasuram.
- Those three temples together are UNESCO's Great Living Chola Temples.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2023 asked who built the Brihadeshwara (Rajarajeshwara) temple at Thanjavur. Answer - Rajaraja I. Fix the pair Rajaraja I = Brihadeshwara, Rajendra I = Gangaikonda Cholapuram. Swapping these two is the commonest slip.

CURRENT LINK

Current link: on 27 July 2025, at Gangaikonda Cholapuram during the Aadi Thiruvathirai festival, the Prime Minister released a 1000-rupee commemorative coin honouring Rajendra Chola I, marking a thousand years of his northern march and maritime expedition. Position as of September 2026. Coin-plus-anniversary items like this feed straight into the current-affairs block, and the history question that follows is always Rajendra I - Gangaikondachola - Srivijaya.

Chola local self-government - Uttaramerur, and why it matters

This is the one piece of south Indian history that gets asked as a concept, not as a name. Chola villages ran themselves. There were three kinds of village body, depending on who lived there. And the elections to their committees were run by lottery, not by show of hands - which is why the inscriptions describing them are famous. The record is at Uttaramerur in Tamil Nadu, in inscriptions of Parantaka I, around 920 CE.

- Ur - the assembly of an ordinary village of landholders.
- Sabha or Mahasabha - the assembly of a brahmadeya village, that is a village granted to brahmanas.
- Nagaram - the assembly of merchants in a trading town.
- Nadu was the larger unit above the village; its assembly was the nattar.
- Kudavolai - the pot-ticket system: names on palm-leaf tickets drawn from a pot by a young boy.
- Those elected sat on variyams - committees for the tank, garden, gold, justice and the annual accounts.
- Qualifications were strict - ownership of land and a house, an age range, knowledge of the Vedas.
- Failure to submit accounts disqualified a man and his relatives from office.

YAAD RAKHO

Three words carry this whole topic - Ur, Sabha, Nagaram; and one word carries the method - kudavolai. If you remember Uttaramerur - Parantaka I - kudavolai - variyam, you have the full mark.

- Hoysalas - capital Dwarasamudra (Halebidu); Vishnuvardhana built the Chennakeshava temple at Belur; Vesara style.
- Sacred Ensembles of the Hoysalas were inscribed by UNESCO in 2023.
- Kakatiyas - capital Warangal (Orugallu); Rudramadevi ruled as a woman and was praised by Marco Polo.
- Prataparudra II was defeated by Delhi in 1323, ending the Kakatiyas.
- Ramappa or Rudreshwara temple at Palampet, a Kakatiya temple, became a UNESCO site in 2021.
- Sangam-age emblems - Chola tiger, Pandya fish, Chera bow and arrow; the three are the *muvendar*.
- Pandya capital Madurai, port Korkai; Chera capital Vanji, port Muziris.

REVISION RECAP

1. Sri Gupta founder, only Maharaja; Chandragupta I first Maharajadhiraja, Licchavi marriage, Gupta era 319-320 CE.
2. Prayag Prashasti - Harisena, champu Sanskrit, on an Ashokan pillar; Aryavarta uprooted, Dakshinapatha reinstated.
3. Samudragupta - Kaviraja, lyrist coins, Napoleon of India (V.A. Smith's phrase).
4. Chandragupta II - Sakari, first Gupta silver, Navaratna, daughter Prabhavati married Vakataka Rudrasena II.
5. Prabhavati Gupta ruled as regent for Divakarasena; Poona copper plates.
6. Fa-Hien under Chandragupta II, Fo-Kuo-Ki; Hiuen Tsang under Harsha, Si-yu-ki.
7. Kumaragupta I founded Nalanda, peacock coins; Skandagupta - Hunas, Junagadh and Bhitari inscriptions.
8. Gupta ladder - Bhukti (Uparika), Vishaya (Vishayapati), Vithi, Grama; Kumaramatyas top cadre; dinara.
9. Harsha 606-647, Thanesar to Kannauj, stopped by Pulakeshin II at the Narmada.

10. Bana wrote *Harshacharita* and *Kadambari*; Harsha wrote *Nagananda*, *Ratnavali*, *Priyadarshika*.
11. Tripartite struggle for Kannauj - Palas, Gurjara-Pratiharas, Rashtrakutas.
12. Gopala elected, built Odantapuri; Dharmapala founded Vikramshila and Somapura; Jayadeva at Lakshmanasena's court.
13. Rashtrakutas - Dantidurga founder, Krishna I built Ellora Kailasa, Amoghavarsha I wrote *Kavirajamarga*.
14. Aihole inscription - Ravikirti, Meguti temple, Saka 556, on Pulakeshin II.
15. Narasimhavarman I took Vatapi in 642 CE, title Vatapikonda; Mahendravarman I wrote *Mattavilasa Prahasana*.
16. Pallava architecture - Mahendra, Mamalla, Rajasimha, Nandivarman stages.
17. Rajaraja I - Brihadeshwara 1010 CE; Rajendra I - Gangaikonda Cholapuram, Srivijaya expedition.
18. Uttaramerur, Parantaka I, c. 920 CE - kudavolai lottery, variyam committees; Ur, Sabha, Nagaram.
19. Hoysalas - Belur and Halebidu, UNESCO 2023; Kakatiyas - Warangal, Rudramadevi, Ramappa UNESCO 2021.
20. Sangam emblems - Chola tiger, Pandya fish (Madurai, Korkai), Chera bow (Vanji, Muziris).